

LOOT TABLE WORKS | PLAY TONIGHT

GULLWATCH BEACON

SIGNAL AT GULLWATCH

A complete system-neutral fantasy one-shot for 3-6 players

10-minute prep | 3-4 hours | Map, tokens, handouts, and run sheet included



Run This Tonight

An abandoned sea beacon is broadcasting a false harbor code. Reach the tower before the flood tide, discover who changed the signal, and decide whether its drowned keeper deserves rescue or release.

Players	3-6	Play time	3-4 hours
Prep	10 minutes	Rules	Any fantasy system

10-minute preparation

- Choose low, seasoned, or heroic scaling for the whole session.
- Open the gridless map on a shared screen or print the GM map.
- Put six marks beside Flood Tide and four beside False Signal.
- Read the four GM truths and the first scene's strong start.
- Begin. Translate only the profiles that enter play.

Strong start

Three amber pulses burn through the storm from a beacon that has been dark for thirteen years. Far offshore, a grain ship answers and turns toward the reef. Tidewarden Mara Vale presses a brass signal key into the party's hand: 'You have one tide to make that light tell the truth.'

What is really happening

- The beacon's Brineworn Orb stores the final memory of Keeper Orren Saye.
- Corsair scout Nera Voss altered the shutters to lure one specific guild ship onto the reef.
- The false signal agitates the glassfin creatures nesting in the tide pools.
- The beacon can be repaired, retuned, extinguished, or surrendered to Orren; no single ending is mandatory.

Session Control

Advance a clock only when the fiction changes. Never spend a clock step to punish ordinary caution or table discussion.

Flood Tide (6 steps)

- **Advance:** The party suffers a major setback, abandons a route, or spends extended time searching.
- 1-2: Spray makes exposed movement uncertain.
- 3-4: The low paths flood and the wreck route closes.
- 5: The bridge begins to fail; every crossing carries a consequence.
- 6: The grain ship reaches the reef and the finale begins under rescue pressure.

False Signal (4 steps)

- **Advance:** Nera or Orren retains control after a scene changes.
- 1: A distant ship answers the beacon.
- 2: Harbor traffic begins following the false lane.
- 3: The grain ship commits to the reef channel.
- 4: Impact is imminent; stopping the light alone will not save the ship.

Four-scene route

Scene	Decision	New information
1. Answering Ship	Choose the route and Nera's role	The signal is deliberate
2. Keeper's Room	Investigate, rush, or make contact	Orren lives in the Orb
3. Brass Stair	Trade speed for preservation	The mechanism can be retuned
4. Light Remembers	Name what the party protects	Every ending changes the coast

People and Approaches

Mara Vale

Role: tidewardens and employer

Wants: The harbor protected without exposing the guild's neglected beacon records.

Tell: Counts every signal pulse against her thumb.

Leverage: Carries the only current harbor codebook.

Nera Voss

Role: brine corsair scout

Wants: The guild ship wrecked so its stolen relief cargo can be recovered.

Tell: Never stands between someone and an exit.

Leverage: Knows the safe sequence for crossing the damaged bridge.

Orren Saye

Role: memory bound to the beacon

Wants: A final true signal sent in his name before the Orb is removed.

Tell: Repeats the last word spoken by anyone entering the lantern room.

Leverage: Can rotate the shutters and calm the glassfin brood.

Three routes to the tower

Broken Bridge (fast) - The center span drops when two heavy loads occupy it. **Opportunity:** Nera's rope marks reveal a stable crossing rhythm.

Cliff Ladder (steady) - The upper rungs are visible from the tower shutters. **Opportunity:** Reaches the keeper's side door and bypasses the bridge confrontation.

Wreck Channel (slow) - Closes when Flood Tide reaches step 3. **Opportunity:** Reveals the cut signal cable and proof of deliberate sabotage.



Map key: 1 bridge break | 2 lantern mechanism | 3 cliff ladder | 4 wreck channel | 5 glassfin reef

1. The Answering Ship

Purpose: Put visible lives at stake and give the party ownership of the approach.

Beyond the rain, the beacon answers itself in three amber pulses. A ship replies from the dark water. Below, the tide withdraws through black pools like a held breath.

Players can see

The bridge is damaged but currently passable.

A hooded figure moves between crates on the mainland side.

The tide exposes a wreck and a cable running toward the tower.

Meaningful choices

Confront or bargain with Nera before crossing.

Take the bridge, cliff ladder, or wreck channel.

Send a warning signal from the cliff and advance the Flood Tide once.

Pressure: Nera cuts one bridge support if cornered, but prefers a deal to a fight.
Exit: The party reaches the tower or secures Nera as an ally, captive, or active rival.

Low: Nera acts alone and yields when disarmed or exposed.	Seasoned: Add two corsair deckhands covering the bridge.	Heroic: Nera controls a winch that can split the party across the span.
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2. The Keeper's Room

Purpose: Reveal the human conflict and reward investigation without stalling play.

Salt has furred every hinge. The keeper's desk remains dry beneath a collapsed shutter, its log open to the same unfinished line: I will not send them blind into -

Players can see

A code strip has been overwritten with fresh black wax.

Orren's tools point toward the brass stair whenever the beacon pulses.

Wet footprints enter from the bridge door but do not leave.

Meaningful choices

Restore the log and learn Orren's final signal.

Follow Nera's sabotage trail directly to the lantern room.

Use the old speaking tube to contact the memory in the Orb.

Pressure: At False Signal step 2, the glassfin brood climbs into the room through the broken shutters.
Exit: The party learns at least two truths and chooses whether to approach Orren as threat, witness, or potential ally.

Low: One glassfin stalker retreats from bright light.	Seasoned: Two stalkers coordinate around the desk and stair.	Heroic: A third stalker guards the speaking tube and reacts to lies.
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3. The Brass Stair

Purpose: Force a choice between speed, safety, and preserving evidence.

The tower shudders as the lens rotates overhead. Each amber sweep turns the stair rail translucent, revealing old names etched inside the metal like bones beneath skin.

Players can see	Meaningful choices
The drive chain can be jammed, reversed, or climbed past.	Jam the mechanism and risk breaking the Orb housing.
A counterweight holds the shutters against the true harbor code.	Reverse the chain and lose time while the tide advances.
Orren's name is the last intact engraving.	Climb through the moving assembly and preserve the mechanism.

Pressure: Every failed or abandoned method advances one clock chosen by the GM.

Exit: The party enters the lantern room with the mechanism intact, damaged, or stopped.

Low: Telegraph every moving part before it becomes dangerous.	Seasoned: The counterweight drops after the first intervention.	Heroic: Nera or a stalker contests the stair while the mechanism moves.
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4. A Light That Remembers

Purpose: Resolve the dilemma through action, negotiation, or confrontation.

The Brineworn Orb hangs inside a cage of turning brass. A figure of salt-white light stands within it, one hand on the shutters. 'Tell me,' Orren says in your own voices, 'which truth should the coast remember?'

Players can see	Meaningful choices
The true signal can still redirect the grain ship.	Repair the true signal and preserve Orren in the beacon.
Removing the Orb will erase Orren unless his memory is transferred.	Transfer Orren into the signal key, then remove the Orb.
Nera's target ship carries relief cargo taken from her flooded district.	Expose the guild theft over the harbor code and accept the political fallout.
	Destroy the mechanism, then mount a direct rescue of the ship.

Pressure: When either clock fills, saving every objective becomes impossible; the party must name what they protect.

Exit: The ship's fate, Orren's fate, Nera's cause, and the beacon's future are each stated aloud.

Low: Orren accepts any honest plan that saves the ship.	Seasoned: Orren demands his final signal before relinquishing control.	Heroic: The Orb fractures, requiring two simultaneous objectives while the brood attacks.
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Profiles and Conversion

Use the low, seasoned, or heroic endurance value. One successful risky action normally removes 1 mark; a decisive exploit removes 2. Pressure is the severity of a consequence on a 1-5 scale, not a damage value.

Profile	Intent and moves	Break condition
Brine Corsair Scout Pressure 2 2 / 4 / 6 marks	Stay mobile and keep an exit open. Cut a route behind the party Trade a secret for position Mark a target for an ally	Proof that the target cargo was stolen from flood survivors.
Glassfin Stalker Pressure 2 2 / 4 / 6 marks	Hunt whatever disturbs the signal resonance. Emerge from reflective water Drive prey toward an exposed edge Retreat from sudden warm light	A correctly tuned pulse or a clear path back to the tide pools.
Saltwake Memory Pressure 3 3 / 5 / 7 marks	Repeat the final duty until someone names a better one. Rotate the shutters Speak through a companion's voice Animate corroded keeper tools	A witnessed true signal or the recovery of Orren's complete last log.

Conversion principles

- Translate marks into the durability scale your game already uses.
- Use each move as intent and consequence, not as a proprietary rules action.
- If a profile is outnumbered, improve position or add a scene complication before adding endurance.
- Every opponent has a break condition so negotiation and clever play remain complete solutions.

Rewards

Brineworn Signal Key: Once per journey, reveal the safest visible route through weather, crowds, or confused traffic. **Cost:** The key repeats the last warning it heard whenever danger is ignored.

Orren's Harbor Code: Establish credibility with Saltglass pilots, wardens, and archive crews. **Cost:** Using the code creates a record that the harbor guild can trace.

End the Session with Consequences

Ask the players to state the ship's fate, Orren's fate, Nera's cause, and the beacon's future. Then choose or combine an ending.

- True Light: the ship clears the reef and Gullwatch returns to service under new witnesses.
- Carried Memory: Orren leaves inside the signal key and the dark tower becomes a contested salvage site.
- Public Reckoning: the guild theft is broadcast, saving the ship while igniting a harbor strike.
- Broken Beacon: the party saves survivors directly, but navigation along the coast becomes dangerous for weeks.

Expand the Coast

This adventure is complete as delivered. These optional \$3 packs add reusable material for building more sessions in the same world.

Use	Optional pack	Price
Build more tactical locations	Fantasy Encounter Room Data Kit	\$3
Connect more playable objectives	Fantasy Quest Contract & Reward Data Kit	\$3
Give every threat coherent rewards	Enemy Loot Table & Drop Profile Kit	\$3

Credits and disclosure

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